

EMPTY YOUR CUP

Why Letting Go Unlocks Better Writing



How Belief Becomes Architecture

In 1956, psychologist George Kelly introduced what he called Personal Construct Theory. His argument was simple and radical: human beings don't experience reality directly. They experience it through a system of constructs — mental frameworks built from prior experience that tell us what to expect, how to interpret what we see, and where to look for solutions.

Those constructs are not passive. They are active filters. They determine which information enters conscious awareness and which gets discarded before you ever notice it.

Here's the implication for writers.

The theory you wrote down mentally isn't just a thought you have about your character writing. It's a construct — and like all constructs, it has been actively shaping what you see when you look at your work. It has been deciding what counts as evidence, what counts as failure, and what counts as a fix worth trying.

When you read a flat scene and your construct says *talent problem*, you don't look for a method. You look for evidence of whether you have talent. When it says *I need more research*, you open another character worksheet instead of sitting with

the scene. When it says *some writers can do this and some can't*, you file the flat scene as data about which category you belong to.

The construct isn't helping you see the problem. It is the problem.

Why Intelligence Makes This Worse

Here is the part that no one tells writers. Intelligent people are better at this. Not better at emptying the cup — better at keeping it full.

Psychologist Jonathan Haidt's research on motivated reasoning demonstrates that the more cognitively sophisticated a person is, the more effectively they can generate reasons to support an existing belief. Intelligence doesn't protect against fixed constructs. It arms them.

This means that the writer who has thought most carefully about why their characters are flat — who has the most articulate, well-reasoned explanation for the problem — is often the writer most resistant to a new frame. Not because they're stubborn. Because they're smart. Their explanation is good. It accounts for the evidence. It feels true.

The question is not whether the explanation is good. The question is whether it's useful. And a belief that sends you looking in the wrong direction — however intelligent, however articulate — is costing you every time you sit down to write.

The Mechanism: Why Your Characters Are Already There

Carl Jung's observation about the unconscious wasn't mystical. It was structural.

The conscious mind — the part doing the explaining, the analyzing, the crafting — processes roughly forty to fifty bits of information per second. The unconscious processes an estimated eleven million. The gap between what you know and what you can access at the keyboard is not a gap in knowledge. It's a gap in bandwidth.

Your characters are not absent from your imagination. The complexity you feel when you think about them — the way they move, what they're afraid of, what they'd never say — is real. It exists. It's in there.

The problem is that the path from unconscious knowing to conscious articulation runs directly through your constructs. And if those constructs are pointing you

toward talent assessment or research or technique — the character knowledge never makes it to the page. It gets rerouted before it arrives.

This is why more research rarely closes the gap. You're adding content to a system that already has more content than it can retrieve. More input does not improve retrieval. A better retrieval method does.

That method is questioning. Specifically, the right question held long enough for the third or fourth answer to surface — the answer you didn't know you had. That's what the next two lectures are built around.

But it only works if the construct you arrived with isn't intercepting the question before it can land.

What Openness Actually Is

The lecture mentioned the Big Five. Let me be more specific about what openness means in practice — because it's not what most people think.

Openness to experience is not enthusiasm. It's not optimism. It's not a personality type you either have or don't.

Psychologist Scott Barry Kaufman, one of the leading researchers on creativity and the Big Five, describes openness as the drive to *engage with information for its own sake* — to let something new arrive without immediately evaluating it against existing frameworks. It is, in cognitive terms, the willingness to delay construct-matching long enough for a different pattern to emerge.

That delay is what I am asking for.

Not a permanent suspension of judgment. Not the abandonment of craft instincts built over years. Just a deliberate, temporary pause in the construct-matching process — long enough for the method in this course to reach the knowledge you already have.

Kaufman's research also shows something important: openness is not fixed. It is a state as much as a trait. The same person can be more or less open depending on context, intention, and preparation. Which means the sentence you wrote down — and the act of deliberately setting it aside — is not a personality exercise. It's a cognitive preparation.

You are making yourself more open. On purpose. Right now.

The One Shift That Changes Everything

Carl Rogers spent decades documenting what made the difference between clients who changed and clients who didn't. His conclusion wasn't about technique or insight or the quality of the therapeutic relationship.

It was about suspension.

The clients who changed were the ones who could hold their existing explanation lightly enough to try something different. Not abandon it. Not declare it wrong. Simply — hold it more loosely. Make room.

He called this *psychological safety* — not safety from challenge, but safety to be challenged without the self collapsing in defense.

For writers, the equivalent is this: your existing explanation for why your characters aren't working does not define you as a writer. It is a theory. Theories can be updated. The character knowledge you already have — the complex, layered, specific knowledge of people you've built over a lifetime of observation — that is not going anywhere.

You are not emptying yourself. You are emptying the filter.

The filter is what's been standing between what you know and what you can write.